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A SET OF MULTICOLORED GLAZED CERAMIC STATUES - THREE - GATE GREAT EMPEROR
DATING FROM THE LATE 19TH - EARLY 20TH CENTURY
FROM THE PRIVATE COLLECTION OF LE THANH NGHIA

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THE VALUE OF THE STATUE SET

TAM QUAN DAI DE

OF SAIGON CERAMICS

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Religious artifacts have always held a particularly important place in archaeology. They are not only artistic creations reflecting the technical and aesthetic level of an era, but also "ancient relics" containing profound information about the worldview, value systems, social structure, and spiritual life of past communities. Studying these artifacts, from architectural relics like temples and shrines to statues, ritual objects, and ceremonial items, allows for the reconstruction of a vivid picture of how humans interacted with the supernatural world, how religious doctrines were interpreted and materialized, and the intermingling and transformation of cultural and religious influences. In Vietnam, especially in the Southern region, the religious landscape of the late 19th and early 20th centuries is incredibly rich and diverse. The area of Saigon in the past – Cholon in the present – as a dynamic economic and social center, has become a melting pot of many faith systems: Mahayana Buddhism, Taoism, Confucianism, and folk beliefs of the Vietnamese, Chinese, and other communities. In this context, religious beliefs...*Tam Quan Great Emperor*(The Three Officials), a system of deities originating from Chinese Taoism, has been introduced into the spiritual life of the local inhabitants. Three deities*Heavenly Official's Blessing*(Heavenly Official Bestows Blessings), *The Earth God grants pardon.*(pardon of the local official) and *Water Gate dispels calamity.*(Water Official Relieves Misfortune), has met the spiritual needs of the local inhabitants. The popularity of this belief was further strengthened through the process of "calendarization," which is linked to three major holidays in the year:*Upper Nguyên*(Full Moon of the First Lunar Month)*Central Plains*(Full Moon of the Seventh Month) and*Lower Yuan*(Full Moon of the Tenth Month).

1. ORIGIN AND DEVELOPMENT OF THE THREE-GATE GREAT EMPEROR BELIEF

To interpret the symbolic values of the ceramic statues, a preliminary study of the origins, development, and theological system of the Tam Quan Dai De belief system is essential. This provides a theoretical basis for clarifying the ideological context that gave rise to these material images. The Tam Quan belief system, with its enduring vitality in East Asian culture, is a complex system where the intellectual currents of Taoism, Confucianism, Buddhism, and folk beliefs intersect and shape each other.

1.1. From the "Three-Gate Book-Holding" ritual in Taoist Taoism to the "bureaucratic universe" system

The earliest origins of the Three Gates belief can be traced back to the worship of the three most fundamental natural forces. Researcher Henry Doré identified the initial stage of this belief as the worship of three transcendent powers of the universe: Heaven (Thiên), Earth (Địa), and Water (Thủy), each governed by a deity, collectively known as the Three Gates (S. J. Henry Doré, 1931, p. 31). However, the decisive turning point in the history of this belief occurred during the Eastern Han dynasty, when Zhang Daoling founded the Heavenly Master Dao (Tian Shi Dao).Celestial MastersIn 142 AD, Taoism established a new order based on a covenant between humans and the spiritual world: instead of worshipping natural deities in a haphazard manner, Taoism systematized and "bureaucratized" supernatural forces, transforming them into a clearly defined administrative apparatus capable of directly and systematically intervening in human life (Terry Kleeman, 2016).

It was within this framework that the Tam Quan belief was born. According to Henri Doré's research, the first stage of this belief's development was the worship of three transcendent powers of the universe, collectively known as Tam Quan (Doré, 1931, p. 31). During the reign of Emperor Han Ling (168-190), the Celestial Master Dao associated Tam Quan with an important ritual called*"Tam Quan Thu Thu"*(Three Officials' Handwritten LetterAccordingly, illness and misfortune were seen as direct consequences of sins committed by humans. To be healed, the sick person had to write three petitions clearly stating their name and sins. These three petitions were then sent to three corresponding realms of power: one to Heaven (burned on a mountaintop), one to Earth (buried in the ground), and one to Water (submerged in water). Through this, blessings, forgiveness, and liberation were granted; the effective ritual became a custom, with benefactors offering "five measures of rice" to the sorcerer. This was not merely a natural act of worship, but a significant step in assigning specific judicial functions to these forces.*Heavenly Official bestows blessings*(Blessing)), *The Earth God grants pardon*.(Pardon) and *Water Gate dispels calamity*.(Relieve misfortuneThis division of labor reflects a transition from the worship of natural forces to the establishment of a divine bureaucratic system.

This ritual is not merely a spiritual act, but also a sophisticated simulation of the court's legal procedures. It reveals a worldview in which the universe operates as a giant administrative machine, where every human action is recorded, judged, and decided by divine "officials."

1.2. The process of "calendarization" and the fusion of beliefs

From the ritual of individual patient care, the Celestial Master "upgraded" this ceremony by establishing specific dates and commemorative days for the Three Gates, and it was systematized more deeply during the Eastern Jin Dynasty (317-420), under the influence of Taoist priests.*Kou Qianzhi*(Kou Qianzhi), a major reformer of Taoism. This action by Kou Qianzhi can be seen as a process of "calendricalizing" the belief system. In the 4th century

VI, under the influence of Taoist reformers, the worship of the Three Gates became associated with three major festival periods of the year, known as*Tam Nguyen*(Three YuanThese three days are all full moon days, times of special significance in both the agricultural calendar and East Asian spirituality:

- The Full Moon of the First Lunar Month: Also known as the festival*Upper Nguyên*(Shangyuan), is the auspicious day of the Heavenly Official. This marks the beginning of a new year, an occasion to pray for blessings and peace throughout the year.
- The Full Moon of the Seventh Month: Also known as the festival*Central Plains*(Midsummer), is the auspicious day of the Earth God. This is the middle of autumn, the harvest season is approaching, and it is also an occasion for the Earth God to forgive the sins of the deceased.
- Full Moon of the Tenth Month: Also known as the festival*Lower Yuan*(Lower Yuan), is the auspicious day of the Water God. This marks the beginning of winter, the end of an agricultural cycle, and is an occasion to give thanks and pray for the removal of calamities.

In this way, the Tam Quan belief is no longer limited to Taoist communities but has become an important part of the people's festival calendar. This not only helps Taoism consolidate its position against the strong development of Buddhism but also helps this belief integrate deeply into socio-cultural life, transforming the Tam Quan festivals into important occasions for the community to practice moral values, pray for peace, and give thanks. This arrangement is not arbitrary but contains profound explanations based on the philosophy of Yin-Yang and the I Ching.I Ching).

This not only helped Taoism consolidate its position but also allowed the Tam Quan belief system to integrate deeply into socio-cultural life. In particular, the Trung Nguyen festival on the 15th day of the seventh lunar month had a profound interaction with the Vu Lan Bon festival of Buddhism, creating one of the most important and vibrant spiritual festivals in East Asian culture, and later in Vietnam.

In Taoist belief, the 15th day of the seventh lunar month is the Zhongyuan Festival, the auspicious day of the Earth God, a deity with the function of "forgiving sins." For the souls of the deceased. On this day, the gates of hell are believed to open, and souls are allowed to return to the mortal world. In Buddhist belief, the 15th day of the seventh lunar month is Ullambana, a festival originating from a Buddhist story about the filial piety of Venerable Maudgalyayana. Through his spiritual practice, he saved his mother from the realm of hungry ghosts in hell.

The Earth God's function of "atonement" for the souls of the deceased resonated perfectly with the story of Venerable Moggallana rescuing his mother from the realm of hungry ghosts. This combination created a multi-layered festival, which we now commonly refer to as the Festival of Atonement for the Deceased or the Ghost Month.

The fusion of the Mid-Autumn Festival and the Ghost Festival is a prime example of the "Three Religions in Common Origin" phenomenon in folk religious practices, where different doctrines and rituals do not exclude but complement each other, creating an incredibly rich and enduring cultural-religious complex. On the religious history level, Stephen F. Teiser systematically demonstrated that the Ghost Festival in medieval China was a typical case of Buddhist-Taoist interaction, where the ritual of offering alms to the Sangha (Buddhism) and opening the prison for the pardon of sins (Taoism) converged in the practice of the lay community, creating a "convergent festival" that was both judicial (forgiving sins) and filial (saving the spirits of ancestors) (Teiser, 1988/2020).

1.3. The human-deity figures of Tam Quan Dai De

As beliefs spread, abstract concepts tend to be personified to become more accessible to the masses. The Tam Quan belief system is no exception and has developed two parallel symbolic paradigms.

Firstly, the "primordial energy transformation" model of Taoism. According to scriptures in the Orthodox Taoist Canon such as the "Three Principles of the Three Realms Sutra," the Three Gates are not created by humans, but are "transformed" by the Primordial Heavenly Venerable using the primordial energy of the universe.Qi transformation) and thus it was formed. They are the essence of the cosmic order, governing the three realms through a complex celestial "government" system with the Palace (palace( ), Palace (Prefecture), Cao (Cao), records (official documents, black documents)... This is a reflection and idealization of the bureaucratic apparatus of the Chinese empire, ensuring absolute justice based on the "laws" of Taoism.

Secondly, the "divine personality" archetype in folklore. To make the belief more easily accepted, folk tales have identified Tam Quan with the three ancient sage kings in Confucianism: Yao (Yao), Thuan (Shun) and Vu (YuThis unity is built on a profound correspondence between the merits of the kings and the functions of the gods:

- ***Heavenly Official - Emperor Yao***Emperor Yao established the weather patterns and arranged the heavens and earth; this achievement corresponds to the function of bringing "four blessings."
- ***Earth Official - Emperor Shun***Emperor Shun was an exemplary figure of filial piety, close to the land, and his tolerance corresponded to the function of "forgiving sins."
- ***Water Gate - Emperor Wu***Yu the Great's great achievement in flood control is a wonderful metaphor for the function of "relieving calamities." The synchronization of the Three Gates as the Three Emperors is, in essence, one.

The process of "Confucianizing" a Taoist concept transformed cosmic deities into shining examples of Confucian morality. The parallel existence of these two paradigms—one representing deities formed from energy, the other from humans—shows a wonderful blend of profound philosophy and practical life, giving the Tam Quan belief system enduring vitality and high adaptability in different cultural contexts.

2. THE THREE-GATE STATUE SET OF THE GREAT EMPEROR - SAIGON CERAMICS, A DISTINCTIVE EXAMPLE OF ANCIENT SOUTHERN VIETNAMESE CERAMICS

The Tam Quan Dai De statue set comprises nine statues, divided into three groups corresponding to the three deities and their attendants. Through a combination of material analysis methods, sculpting techniques, glazing techniques, and firing processes, the value of this statue set can be comprehensively deciphered.

2.1. Materials and Shaping Techniques

The materials used are fundamental, determining the technical and aesthetic characteristics of Saigon ceramics. According to research and field surveys, the main material used is plastic clay (plastic material), extracted locally from ancient alluvial deposits distributed along the canal system of old Saigon - now Cholon, typically in areas such as Ruot Ngua Canal, Lo Gom Canal, Xom Dat, and Giac Vien.*(Huynh Ngoc Trang, 2016; Nguyen Thi Hau, 2000, pp. 129-133).*

In terms of mineral composition, scientific analyses of pottery samples excavated from the Hung Loi pottery kiln site have indicated that the main components of Saigon clay include three main mineral groups: kaolinite, illite (alkali), and montmorillonite (Nguyen Thi Hau & Dang Van Thang, 2001, p. 116). Of these, kaolinite is the core component, providing the necessary plasticity for shaping; illite enhances cohesion and mechanical strength; and montmorillonite, although only present in a small proportion, significantly increases plasticity. The natural combination of these three mineral groups creates a material with ideal properties: both ductile and flexible for complex shaping techniques, while also possessing relatively good stability during firing.

However, to control shrinkage, increase heat resistance, and ensure the durability of large-sized products like the Three-Arched Gate statues, artisans combined malleable clay with lean materials (non-plastic fillers). These materials include feldspar, which acts as a flux to lower firing temperature and promote vitrification of the glaze, and quartz, used as an inorganic filler to reduce shrinkage, create a solid "framework" for the ceramic body, and minimize the risk of deformation.

Cracks and fractures in the kiln (Phi Ngoc Tuyen, 2005, p. 39). Thus, it can be seen that the quality of the statues comes not only from the craftsman's skill, but also from a deep understanding and mastery of the materials, a process that seamlessly combines generational knowledge and experience with the scientific properties of the local raw materials.

The Tam Quan statue set is large in size and complex in structure, requiring the artisans of Buu Nguyen workshop to skillfully combine many different sculpting techniques, from traditional craftsmanship to the use of molds, to ensure uniformity and sophistication.

Main character

The main body of the three Great Emperors, depicted in a "seated posture on a rectangular pedestal," and the large throne itself were crafted using a hand-molding technique with rolled strips of clay. This is an ancient technique that allows artisans to create large-scale products by rolling strips of clay, overlapping them, and smoothing them together to form the basic shape. A notable technical detail noted in the appraisal report is the "clearly separated back of the throne," indicating that the artisans crafted the body of the statue and the back of the throne as two separate parts before joining them. This demonstrates a modular production approach.[1] This not only makes it easier to create intricate details like the "religious throne body with stylized rosette carvings," but also minimizes the risk of cracking during drying and firing for a large artwork.

Creating detailed shapes

The intricate, sharp, and consistent details on all three statues were most likely created using molds, which were then attached to the main body. The clearest evidence includes:

The crowns and headdresses of the Heavenly Officials are "round, pointed hats (similar to the Imperial Court hats)", while the Earth Officials and Water Officials wear "flat-topped hats". All are decorated with exquisitely crafted and consistent "two dragons worshipping a pearl" relief motifs, a detail that is difficult to replicate consistently by hand across many products.

The faces and hands, the uniformity in facial expressions, and especially the hand posture of "clasped in front of the chest, left hand inside, right hand outside" on all three statues are clear indications of the use of molds to ensure consistency and standardization for the set of statues.

The imperial robes, with their motifs such as the "four-clawed dragon and embossed cloud patterns," are repetitive and highly detailed. Particularly noteworthy are the individual motifs on the bodice of each deity, such as the "floral and fruit patterns" of the Earth God and the Chinese characters.life" *(Longevity)*The seal-like patterns of Thủy Quan are typical examples of the use of molds to create intricate decorative patterns before attaching them to statues.

The "heart-suppressing" hole

A distinctive ritualistic detail noted on all three statues is a square hole in the back. The appraisal report clearly states: "The statue's back has a square hole (where ceremonial items, known as the 'Statues' or 'Heart-Sealing'), are placed." This is not a technical flaw, but an integral part of the statue-making process. This square hole is intentionally created so that after completion, rituals of spiritual immersion are performed, placing sacred items such as scriptures inside to "breathe life" into the statue, transforming it from a ceramic work into a spiritual object ready for worship.

In relation to contemporary pottery production centers in Southern Vietnam, the shaping techniques of the Buu Nguyen kiln exhibit a distinct identity, especially when compared to Bien Hoa pottery. Bien Hoa pottery, under the guidance of the Bien Hoa School of Fine Arts since 1903, showed a clear trend towards industrialization, moving towards product standardization through the systematic use of plaster molds.

In contrast, this set of Three Great Emperor statues is a concrete example of a different technical approach, a harmonious blend of tradition and practicality. The artisans of the Buu Nguyen workshop did not abandon the traditional hand-sculpting technique that brings life to large forms, but skillfully integrated it with molding techniques to ensure sharpness and consistency in the intricate decorative details. This sculpting method allowed their works to meet the necessary standards of a set of religious statues while preserving the "artistic individuality" and soul of traditional craftsmanship.

2.2. Glazing and firing techniques

Glazing and firing techniques play a decisive role, not only shaping the aesthetic value but also ensuring the durability and functionality of ceramic products. For a high-end set of religious statues like the Tam Quan Dai De set from the Buu Nguyen kiln, analyzing these two stages allows us to identify the high level of technical skill and unique identity of the fine art ceramics of the Don Cay Mai region in particular and Saigon ceramics in general. The set of statues demonstrates the skillful application of two distinctive glazes.

Yellow glaze (Eel skin glaze): The three main statues (Heavenly Official, Earthly Official, Water Official) are covered with yellow glaze, a type of glaze also known in folklore as eel skin glaze. This is a traditional glaze belonging to the ash-silicate glaze group, with iron oxide (Fe) as the main coloring component.$_2$THE$_3$The glaze contains a medium iron content (0.5-2%), crafted from readily available local materials such as wood ash, red clay, and lime. The glaze's color ranges from straw yellow to earthy yellow and light brown, resulting from the iron ratio and firing conditions in an oxidizing environment at temperatures of approximately 1150-1200°C. With advantages such as low cost, high durability, and a subdued, warm hue suitable for religious spaces, Yellow glaze became the optimal choice for religious and everyday products popular in Southern Vietnam. In particular, the chemical properties of Saigon clay, with its high iron oxide (Fe) content, were a key factor.$_2$THE$_3$ and FeO) are relatively high, as noted in the analysis of samples from the Hung Loi furnace.*(Nguyen Thi Hau & Dang Van Thang, 2001, p. 116)*This is also a favorable natural factor, helping the yellow glaze achieve its characteristic depth and warmth when fired in an oxidizing environment.

Multicolored glaze: Used for the attendant statues, the multicolored glaze represents a pinnacle of technique, requiring exquisite craftsmanship and clearly reflecting the stratification in the production and consumption of Saigon ceramics. To create a vibrant color palette, artisans combined a base glaze (usually clear or gold) with metal oxides capable of creating distinctive colors, for example: cobalt for deep blue, copper for green, and manganese for purplish-brown. This technique was achieved by applying separate patches of color to each raised detail on the product. On the attendant statues of the set, this technique is vividly demonstrated through details recorded in the appraisal report such as "the shoulders and sleeves are blue with brown trim" or "the long dress is green, the shoulders are blue with brown trim," along with the "phoenix" motif. After coloring, the product is fired at high temperatures, ranging from 1150-1200°C in an oxidizing environment, to ensure the color layers remain stable, do not bleed, and achieve the necessary gloss. Due to the complex technical requirements and high material costs, multi-colored glaze techniques are usually only found on high-end religious and architectural decorative products, thus affirming the exceptional artistic and economic value of this set of statues.

Given their large scale and high artistic quality, the Tam Quan statues may have been fired in the most advanced kilns of the time in Saigon. Based on archaeological evidence and comparative research, it can be confirmed that the type of kiln used was a dragon kiln.Dragon Kiln), either tube kilns or enclosed kilns (gourd kilns). These are two types of kilns originating from China, introduced and developed in old Saigon by the Chinese diaspora pottery community, and particularly suitable for large-scale production. These kilns have a long, sloping structure, allowing for the simultaneous firing of large quantities of products at high temperatures, reaching up to 1250°C, and maintaining thermal stability—a key factor in firing thick ceramic bodies and melting complex glazes.

To protect the intricate details and glaze quality of an important work like the Three-Gate Statues, the use of saggars (or kiln enclosures) is an almost mandatory technical step. The statues are carefully placed inside refractory clay boxes before being placed in the kiln. This technique creates a separate micro-space, protecting the product from direct flames and ash, preventing glaze burning.

The "heart-concealing" hole at the back of the statue of Emperor Tian Guan.
Photo: Harry Nguyen Hung Cuong

1. Production thinking based on separate, independent departments (i.e. These are individual "modules"), which are then assembled into a complete product finished product.

It prevents foaming or discoloration, while stabilizing the temperature and chemical environment surrounding the product, helping the glaze flow evenly and develop the best color.

The simultaneous application of large-scale kiln systems and the technique of enclosed firing not only minimized the risk of damage but also served as important archaeological evidence, demonstrating the technical skill and professional organizational thinking of the Buu Nguyen kiln. The entire process, from glaze preparation to fire control, was carried out based on experience accumulated over generations, representing the pinnacle of handcrafted pottery in Saigon in the early 20th century.

2.3. Studying each group of statues

The Tam Quan Dai De statue set from Buu Nguyen kiln is a complete collection of artifacts and antiques. It represents a system of theological doctrines and judicial functions of each deity in the belief system. Each group of statues is sculpted with distinct figurative characteristics, accurately reflecting the role and power of each deity within the "bureaucratic universe" system. The statue set perfectly embodies the divine authority and functions of the Tam Quan in Taoist and folk beliefs.

Group of statues

HEAVENLY OFFICE

The group of Heavenly Official statues clearly demonstrates the role of bestowing blessings. The Great Heavenly Official is the largest in the set, measuring 90cm high and 38cm wide, seated on a grand pedestal (38x44.5x12.4cm). Seated in a serene posture, the Heavenly Official wears a round, conical hat (similar to a ceremonial hat). His face is depicted with a benevolent expression, a slight smile, open eyes, and large ears, clearly portraying the countenance of a supreme being who bestows blessings.

According to *PGS.TS* ***Tran Hong Lien***The former Director of the Center for Ethnology and Religion - Institute of Social Sciences of the Southern Region stated:

> *"With both hands clasped in front of the chest in the solemn posture of the One-Finger Heaven-Supporting Mudra, a special hand gesture, with the thumb pointing straight up to the sky and the other four fingers curled inward, signifying that with just one finger, one can support the entire sky. It should be noted that this hand gesture, as its name suggests, is only used by the Supreme Jade Emperor, because in his role as an all-powerful, all-knowing, and all-awakened being, and with his power, this hand gesture has the ability to resolve all evil and negative events, transforming space from bad to good, from dirty to pure, clean, and pristine...".*

This is a benevolent expression that perfectly corresponds to its function."*Heavenly Official's Blessing*"(Heavenly Official Bestows Blessings). The decorative statue is dressed in a "dragon robe," with two dragons on either side of its shoulders, its face looking straight ahead, featuring a four-clawed dragon and raised clouds. The underside of the robe has a water wave pattern, and it wears a belt and boots.

His role is concretized by two attendants standing beside him, wearing long robes adorned with "decorative motifs of phoenixes, waves, and symmetrical clouds," a symbol of the rank of a civil official, and wearing hemp and boots. One attendant stands to the right of the statue of the Heavenly Official, wearing an ivory white robe with green shoulders, holding a brush; the other stands to the left of the statue of the Heavenly Official, wearing a green robe with blue shoulders, holding a book, one end resting on the left shoulder. Both statues are of the same height, 69cm, transforming the altar into a celestial court where merits and demerits are recorded and approved. These details visually concretize the administrative role of the Heavenly Official, who manages the records of merits and demerits of the celestial beings.

The entire group of statues exudes the solemnity, order, and authority of a cosmic administrative center. This imagery perfectly corresponds to its function."*Heavenly Official's Blessing*"(Heavenly Official Bestows Blessings), the celestial official bestows blessings upon mankind. His benevolent countenance, along with his attendant officials, materialized his role as a supreme "official" of the heavenly court, receiving requests and approving blessings.

Group of statues

GEOGRAPHY

The group of statues of the Earth God exudes the solemnity necessary for judgment. Emperor Quan Dai De is 77.5cm tall and 38cm wide, also seated on a throne and wearing a "heavenly crown".The biggest difference lies in the facial expression, which is sculpted to be "round." "Bulging eyes, slightly pursed lips," creating an imposing, even somewhat stern appearance.Carved. The statue is wearing a long robe, with two dragons sculpted in relief on either shoulder, their faces looking straight ahead. Beneath the robe are waves, with a central flap depicting flowers, wearing hemp, wearing boots. One price Archaeological findings, particularly on the pedestal of the Earth God statue, reveal clear inscriptions, confirming its authenticity. The designated place of production is "Embankment Wharf" *(De Ngan Phu - De Ngan Wharf)* and the name of the pottery kiln is "Baoyuan make" *(Created by Buu Nguyen).*

The two attendants accompanying them were about 66-68cm tall, and also wore robes with "decorative emblems in the shape of birds." The phoenix and hands in grasping postures or holding objects, or a "notebook," further reinforce this. Their role was to assist in the administration of justice within the territory. These two attendants were also like two The attendants of the Heavenly Official statues, the only difference being that they wear tall, round hats.

The dignified appearance of the Earth God perfectly matches his function."*The Earth God grants forgiveness*"(land official pardon"Forgiveness" is not simply a matter of granting a favor, but first and foremost requires examination. to judge and pass justice on the sins of all beings and souls. Therefore, the image. His statue must embody the authority and solemnity necessary for its execution. administer justice within the boundaries of the territory.

Group of statues

WATER GATE

The Water God, standing 78.2cm tall, has a similar appearance to the Earth God, complete with a "heavenly crown" and "dragon robe." However, his face is depicted as "round, with open eyes and a slightly smiling mouth," reflecting a balance between majesty and benevolence. He wears a dragon robe with dragons on either shoulder, their faces looking straight ahead, and water waves beneath the robe. A particularly unique and valuable iconographic detail is the embossed Chinese characters on the bodice of his robe.life" *(Longevity)*Seal and floral patterns.

This detail is a very subtle interpretation. His main function is "Water Guardian who resolves calamities" (Water Official Relieves Misfortune), the underwater deity saves living beings from calamities. By adding the symbol of "Longevity," the artisans directly linked the averting of misfortune with humanity's deepest aspiration for a long and peaceful life. This is a clear testament to the process of localization and enrichment of the symbolic meaning of the original belief within the cultural context of Southern Vietnam. Similarly to the Earth Deity statue, the Water Deity statue also bears an inscription identifying its place of origin as "Embankment Wharf" *(The Mansion's Title)*[2] and the name of the pottery kiln is "Baoyuan" *(Created by Buu Nguyen)*from the Buu Nguyen kiln, further enhancing the documentary value of the entire collection.

The accompanying attendants, approximately 67.5cm tall, are similarly sculpted to the groups above, completing the trinity of power of the water realm, wearing tall, round hats like those of the Earth God. His main function is...*"Water Gate dispels calamity"*(Water Official Relieves Misfortune) to help sentient beings escape all calamities and misfortunes. The addition of the character "Thọ" (longevity) on the dragon robe by the artisans of the Bửu Nguyên kiln is a subtle interpretation. "Giải ách" (relieving calamities) not only means overcoming immediate misfortunes, but also aims for a long and peaceful life. Thus, the image of the Water God here directly links the function of dispelling calamities with the deepest human desire for longevity, showing the localization and enrichment of the symbolic meaning of the original belief.

2. De Ngan Phu - De Ngan Wharf, and since De Ngan refers to Saigon, De Ngan Wharf is a Saigon River wharf. At the beginning of the 20th century, the Saigon River was filled in to form Hai Thuong Lan Ong Street and Le Quang Sung Street, which connected. The Saigon River wharf is most likely the point where the head of the Saigon River (now the beginning of Le Quang Sung Street) meets the Lo Gom Canal (now Lo Gom Street). Lo Buu Nguyen is likely located in this Saigon River wharf area.

Letter "Embankment Wharf" - De Ngan Phu
on the pedestal of the statue of the Great Emperor of the Underworld.
Photo: Harry Nguyen Hung Cuong

Letter "Baoyuan"- Created by Buu Nguyen"
on the pedestal of the statue of the Great Emperor of the Underworld.
Photo: Harry Nguyen Hung Cuong

3. PRODUCTS FROM BUU NGUYEN POTTERY IN SAIGON POTTERY

Pottery in old Saigon was a thriving traditional craft from the 18th to the mid-20th century, reflecting the strong cultural exchange between the Vietnamese and the Chinese immigrant community. The old Saigon area, as a dynamic economic and social center, became a convergence point for many technical and aesthetic influences, giving rise to a distinctive style of pottery commonly known as Saigon pottery.

3.1. Social context, beliefs, and needs for ceremonial ceramics in old Saigon

To understand why a pottery workshop like Buu Nguyen focused on producing complex religious works such as the Tam Quan Dai De statue set, it is first necessary to analyze the specific social context and spiritual life of old Saigon during this period. From the 17th century, the Southern region of Vietnam witnessed many large waves of migration of Vietnamese people and especially Chinese people from Southern China. They came here not only bringing their professional skills but also preserving and developing customs, beliefs, and cultural values from their homeland.

The Chinese community, playing a pioneering role in commercial activities, quickly transformed the old Saigon – now Cholon – into a bustling urban center.

Along with building a material life, they had an urgent need to cultivate a spiritual life. Temples, pagodas, and especially community halls (such as the Tuệ Thành Community Hall, Nghĩa An Community Hall, Nhị Phủ Community Hall, etc.) were built not only as places of worship but also as centers of community activity, connecting fellow countrymen, maintaining their identity, and supporting each other in a foreign land. These architectural structures, therefore, were built with great care and splendor, becoming the face of the entire community.

This demand created a vast "market" for artistic ceramic products, especially architectural decorative ceramics and religious ceramics – two of the four main product types of Saigon ceramics. Among these, religious ceramics are a distinctive product line, requiring sophisticated craftsmanship and possessing high symbolic value, directly serving the religious spaces of urban residents in Southern Vietnam. The development of this type of ceramics is closely linked to the activities of many large kilns, mostly managed by Chinese owners, concentrated in areas such as Phu Dinh, Hung Loi, and Cay Mai. Temples, shrines, and assembly halls were lavishly decorated with colorful glazed ceramic sculptures depicting historical and literary events from China. Inside the main halls, altars were solemnly set up with statues, incense burners, candlesticks, etc. Ceramics, with their high durability and brilliant beauty, became the preferred material for realizing these religious spaces. The development of these pottery production centers is inseparable from the natural conditions and infrastructure of Saigon - Gia Dinh. Large pottery kilns were often concentrated along the intricate network of canals such as the Ruot Ngua Canal and the Lo Gom Canal, facilitating the transportation of clay, fuel (firewood, rice husks), and especially the distribution of products throughout Southern Vietnam. This strategic location transformed the pottery kilns into crucial links in the economic and cultural network of the entire region.

3.2. The Buu Nguyen pottery kiln in the production of religious pottery.

To meet this enormous and specialized demand, the Saigon pottery industry developed a clear division of labor and specialization. While some areas like Lai Thieu focused on household pottery, the kilns in Saigon, especially the Buu Nguyen kiln (in the Lo Gom canal area) and Dong Hoa kiln (in the Mai Son area), excelled in the high-end religious and architectural pottery segment.

In that context, the Buu Nguyen pottery kiln (BaoyuanBuu Nguyen kiln emerged as an important brand, specializing in crafting high-end ceramic religious and architectural decorative products. Despite limited historical records, the existence and reputation of Buu Nguyen kiln are firmly established through material evidence: the Chinese inscriptions preserved on artifacts. The Chinese inscription...Baoyuan Kiln" *(Buu Nguyen kiln created)*and "Dowa kiln construction" *(Dong Hoa distillation)* Found on the statue complexes at Thien Hau Temple - Tue Thanh Assembly Hall (Ho Chi Minh City), and communal houses.

Tan Lan (Dong Nai) or Thien Hau Temple (Can Tho City)... and the statues of the Three Great Emperors themselves are prime evidence. This shows that Buu Nguyen kiln has earned the trust of Chinese associations and patrons to craft the most important items for their places of worship.

The presence of the Bửu Nguyên kiln inscription on the Tam Quan Đại Đế statue set, part of Mr. Lê Thanh Nghĩa's private collection, once again confirms the role of this kiln in the large-scale production of religious artifacts. Registering the kiln's name is not only a form of branding but also an important archaeological indicator, helping to determine the age, trace the origin, and reconstruct the production and distribution network of Saigon pottery during its heyday in the late 19th and early 20th centuries.

3.3. The Significance of Producing the Tam Quan Dai De Statue in the Community's Spiritual Life

The crafting of the Tam Quan Dai De (Three Great Emperors) statue set by the Buu Nguyen kiln was not merely a commercial production activity, but also a cultural act that directly and profoundly addressed the spiritual needs of the community. The Tam Quan Dai De belief system is one of the core belief systems brought by the Chinese during their migration. It is one of ten typical religious and belief themes depicted on Saigon ceramics.

This pantheon comprises three supreme deities who govern the three realms of the universe: Heaven, Earth, and Water, each with their respective functions."*Heavenly officials bestow blessings, Earthly officials grant forgiveness, Water officials dispel calamities.*"(Heavenly Official Sends Blessings, Land official pardon, Water Official Relieves MisfortuneThese three functions directly address three of humanity's greatest concerns, especially for a migrant community in the process of building a new life in a new land.

Seeking blessings (the Four Blessings), the aspiration for a prosperous, wealthy, fortunate life with many children and grandchildren. This is the most basic and essential need for settling down and establishing a stable life. The Heavenly Official, with the power to bestow blessings, is the deity they turn to in their prayers for prosperity, the "Greatest Blessing in the World."

Prayers for peace (Forgiveness), addressing worries about sins, karma, and potential misfortunes. The Earth God, with his power to forgive sins for both the living and the deceased, brings spiritual solace, helping people find serenity and peace of mind.

The Water God, with his power to save sentient beings from all calamities, is a spiritual refuge where people pray for protection, shelter, and good health.

Therefore, the worship of the Three Great Deities is a vital religious practice. The statues are not merely decorative objects, but also the physical embodiment of the deities, the centerpiece of the worship space, allowing rituals to be conducted solemnly.

and sacred. The fact that the Buu Nguyen pottery kiln produced a complete, majestic set of statues that adhered to iconographic standards is of immense importance. Essentially, they provided the community with physical embodiments of the deities they revered. These statues became central objects of worship, concretizing and visualizing faith, thereby enabling people to practice and maintain their spiritual lives directly and solemnly. Through this, the set of statues became evidence of the close connection between the pottery artisans' skills and the community's religious life. In other words, pottery making became a means of preserving and expressing cultural and religious values during a turbulent period in Southern Vietnam's history.

Alongside the development of religious life was the development of handicraft industries directly serving religious needs. In the old Saigon - now Cholon, pottery kilns, especially in the De Ngan area (Saigon), emerged as important centers of artistic pottery production, creating countless products, from household items to architectural decorations and exquisite religious artifacts. Saigon pottery products of this period not only reached a high level of technical and artistic skill but also clearly demonstrated cultural exchange and the ability to localize religious themes and imagery. However, research on Saigon pottery and the material manifestation of contemporary religious beliefs often faces certain challenges, mainly due to the fragmentation of source materials. Researchers often have to work with isolated artifacts, lacking information about their original context, or with disjointed collections, making it difficult to identify styles, determine ages, and systematically interpret iconographic values.

In this context, the discovery and recognition of a complete, synchronized set of Tam Quan Dai De statues with clear origin information is a particularly significant scientific event. The set of nine glazed ceramic statues, depicting Tam Quan Dai De and his attendants, owned by private collector Le Thanh Nghia, was officially granted a Certificate of Registration of Artifacts and Antiquities No. 02.../GCN-SVHTT by the Ho Chi Minh City Department of Culture and Sports on June 3, 2025. Based on the appraisal report No. 06/GD-KH2024 from the Ho Chi Minh City Museum of History, the scientific council determined that all the artifacts are antiquities, dating back to the early 20th century.

This collection of artifacts is not only remarkable for its complete size and good condition, but is also particularly valuable because it bears inscriptions in Chinese characters.Embankment Wharf" *(De Ngan Phu/ Saigon Wharf)*and "Baoyuan" *(Created by Buu Nguyen)*On the pedestals of the Earth God and Water God statues, these inscriptions confirm the pottery's origin from the Buu Nguyen pottery kiln - one of the renowned pottery kilns in De Ngan (Saigon) in the early 20th century.

4. CONCLUSION

Statues with inscriptions*"De Ngan Phu" "Buu Nguyen Tao"*This is a highly valuable original document, not only confirming the existence and operation of one of the two most important and famous pottery kilns of Saigon (Buu Nguyen kiln and Dong Hoa kiln), but also providing a set of original artifacts for the study of the high-end ceremonial pottery of this production center. Technical analysis has recreated an advanced production process, from mastering raw materials and combining complex shaping methods to applying diverse glaze formulas and firing techniques in large kilns using firing chambers.

The statue set is a classic physical manifestation of the "bureaucratic cosmology" doctrine in the Tam Quan belief system. Every detail of the statues, from the robes, hand gestures, and thrones of the three Great Emperors to the ritual objects of the attendants, is a sophisticated imitation of the administrative structure of the feudal court, thereby visually conveying the message of a cosmic order governed by law and justice. The creative addition of the "Longevity" symbol on the Water God's dragon robe further demonstrates the process of localization and enrichment of religious meaning within the cultural context of Southern Vietnam.

The set of statues is a vivid testament to the cultural exchange between Vietnam and China in the old Saigon - now Cholon area. It is a product of Saigon pottery techniques, adapted and practiced within the regional cultural environment and materials, creating an artistic style that bears the imprint of Southern China while also reflecting the unique tastes and mindset of the Vietnamese community in the Southern region.

The Tam Quan Dai De statue set is not only a unique work of fine art ceramics, but also an important documentary heritage, contributing to clarifying the close relationship between material production techniques and spiritual and religious life in Southern Vietnam from the late 19th to early 20th centuries.

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